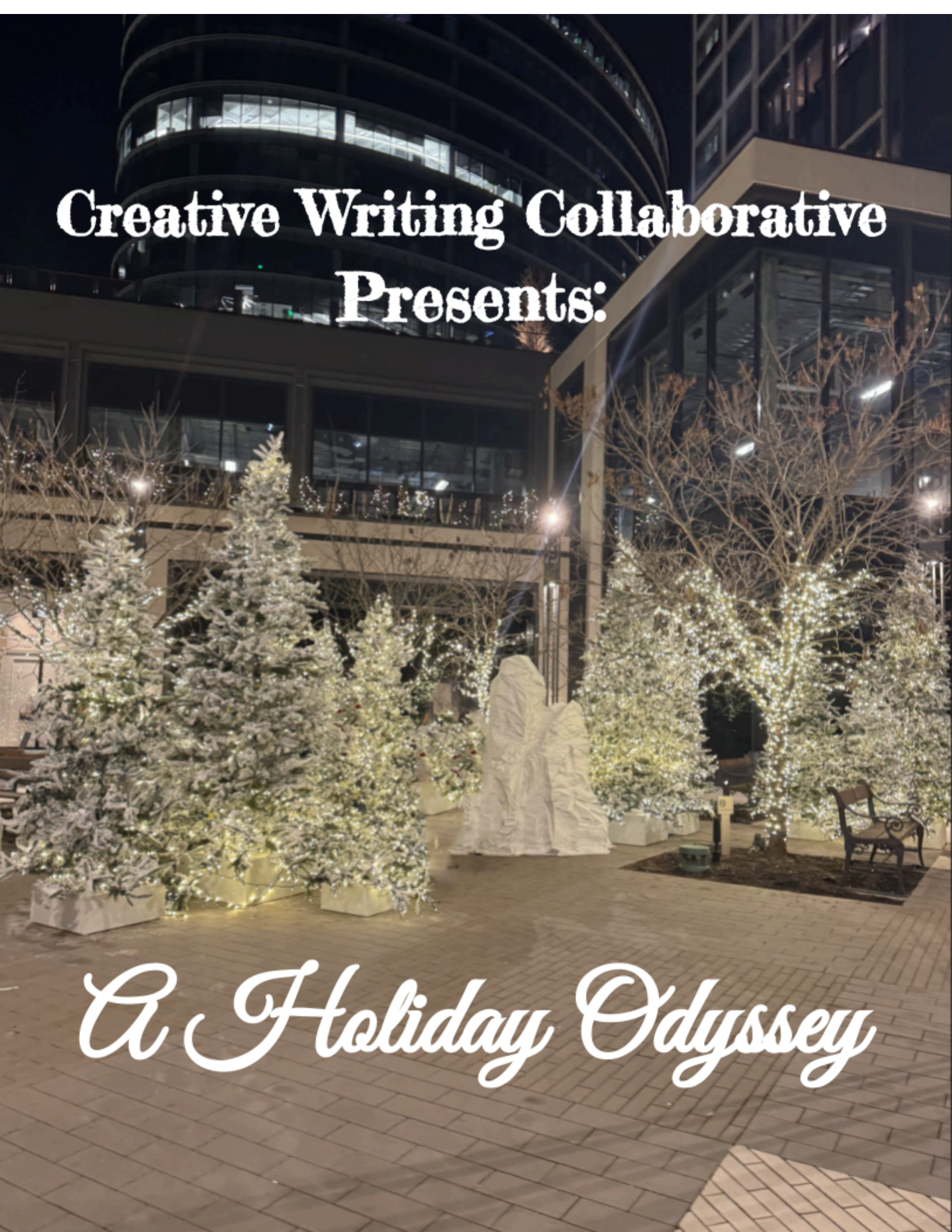




**Creative Writing Collaborative
Presents:**

A Holiday Odyssey

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A Dream Come True

By: Sohaan Ghattamaneni

Once upon a time, there was a 10 year old boy named Alexander. He loved Saint Nicholas Day. He loved to play Musical Money Bag with his brother, Max. Although Alexander and Max were twins, Max was taller and loved his shorter brother.

Since today is a special day, Alexander and Max polished their shoes and then they polished their little sister Karol's shoes. Karol was a very smart 6 year old girl who always thought twice before acting on her thoughts. Karol helped with inside cleaning and decorations. Their mom helped Karol with the stockings and their dad helped the boys with polishing their shoes. The house was decorated with reindeer lights on the flat roof along with a train that held presents. There were Christmas trees in the garage that were covered with white lights and red ribbons

It was the time for Saint Nicholas to come. So everybody slept in peace, except for Alexander. Alexander woke up and heard laughter coming from outside. He asked the people who were laughing, "What is the date today?"

They said, "Today is December 8th." Alexander was so surprised. Saint Nicholas Day is supposed to be on December 6th. The people heard him and told him to keep on going North until he got to Saint Nicholas. So they gave him a compass. He followed the compass and reached the North Pole. He found a magical arctic fox which could talk. His name was Vyper and he was a good friend of Saint Nicholas. The only meat he ate was that of bad guys. He was 55 years old out of his 250 years left to live.

The arctic fox said, "Where are you going my boy? The North Pole is a very cold place."

Alexander said, "I want to meet Saint Nicholas and I will ask him if he could grant me one wish that I can go back in time."

So the arctic fox led Alexander to Saint Nicholas. They traveled 2 days straight.

On the third night, they made a tent which was made out of leaves and branches and they grabbed a few twigs and stones to make a fire and slept for the night.

The next morning, they continued their journey. They finally reached Saint Nicholas.

Saint Nicholas was surprised to see a boy who traveled all the way to the North Pole.

So Saint Nicholas asked the boy, "Why are you here, my boy?"

Alexander replied, "I want to go back in time to celebrate Saint Nicholas Day."

After Alexander said those words, he immediately found himself back in his bed. He realized he had just woken up from a bad dream.

It was Saint Nicholas Day. He went outside to see how much he got in his shoe. Saint Nicholas kept white chocolate in the polished shoe and that was Alexander's favorite. He woke up Max, Karol, his mom and his dad. They all went and looked inside the shoes to find their presents. Alexander got a mint chocolate bar - his favorite! Everybody was happy.

THE END

A Reminiscent Diwali

By: Annika Jivrajani

In the prosperous city of Mumbai, India, excited adolescents sped through the bustling streets, begging their families to buy them various items from the street vendors for the popular holiday of Diwali. Many were laughing joyously, and buying goods knowing that when they go home, they will be bombarded with amusing traditions with their family, such as eating a scrumptious meal and making beautiful rangolis, each filled with different designs.

But in the small town of Karkath, a girl, just about ten years young, had tears streaming down her heavily swollen cheeks, while looking at a picture of a man with the kindest auburn eyes whose face was cleanly shaven. In the photo, he was smiling with his white teeth goofily, while carrying his daughter lovingly on his back. As Saanvi touched the gold frame, her vision now completely became a blur, but somehow, she could still feel herself comfortably on her father's back laughing like there was no tomorrow, while her mother was taking the photo gleefully.

Saanvi hadn't seen her like that for the past year.

As she once again buried her eyes into her cold hands, she heard the door slowly creak open behind her.

"*Saanvi,*" her mother said, not a trace of empathy in her icy voice.

"What do *you* want?" Saanvi said, not removing her hands from her eyes.

"Come downstairs,"

"Why should I?" Her mother sighed in frustration, her arms that were filled with colorful bangles crossed.

Finally, after contemplating, she said, "Because your father would have wanted to."

After hearing this, Saanvi took her hands off her eyes and stared at her mother, her heart burning like a house just set on fire. After staring at her for a rough minute, she finally decided to come downstairs. Saanvi walked down the stairs, her pink cheeks still prominently swollen. As she found her seat on the lengthy marble table, her bright auburn eyes, filled with sorrowness, shifted to the variety of food in front of her. Sitting in front of her, there were warm gulab jamuns topped with the sweetest mango ice cream, a dozen of krispy, apricot-colored puris with a milky snow white chutney, as well as the softest and most paneer tikka masala she had ever seen. Although she was still submerged in a great deal of sadness, her starving stomach could almost taste the beautifully cooked food in front of her. As she was about to put a great amount of paneer on her plate, she was greeted by a bolt of nostalgia.

She remembered last year---when her and her father had cooked the paneer. She remembered her fathers soft hand dipping into the tomato curry, and it slowly going over her cheek. She had retaliated, putting just as much curry on his cheek, right before her mother had shouted at both of them. Just two days before the cancer had completely taken over his body. Just two days before he had vanished---two days before he was never to set eyes on the earth again. Once more, Saanvi's eyes flooded in a puddle of tears, and her appetite was no longer present.

Just as Saanvi was getting up, her little cousin, Kaya, walked up to her and wrapped her warm hands around her, and Saanvi felt the heat from her hands transfer onto her icy body.

“I miss Uncle too,” Kaya said, looking up at Saanvi with tears nearly flooding her cheeks. Saanvi gave a sad smile to Kaya, and brushed a strand of her hair behind her ear. Her eyes fell to Kaya’s bright pink ghagra, filled with mandela patterns.

“You look so pretty!” Saanvi complemented, holding Kaya’s warm hands in hers.

“Thanks.”

“Why don’t I go get dressed?” Saanvi said, seeing that Kaya was about to say ‘you look pretty as well’ but stopped after seeing her ragged pajamas that she had not changed since the beginning of the week.

“Good idea!” Kaya said, relieved. “And while you are doing that you might as well take a shower!”

Subsequent to this, Saanvi went up the carpeted stairs and bathed in hot water for a long period of time, allowing all of her distress to flow down the drain. She used her favorite poppy seed scrub, which she only used on very special occasions. She remembered that she had last used this scrub when she had last gone to compete in the professional spelling bee when she was just seven, in which her father and her had practiced all night for. Despite the fact that she had only placed fifth, she remembered her father buying her ras malai from a street vendor to celebrate her hard work.

As she got out of the bathtub, she put on a beautiful purple chunra chori filled with green mandala designs and various different flowers. She then gently placed her dark, silky hair into a long braid. As she walked back down the stairs, a sense of confidence in her eyes, Kaya pulled her into the dining room in which they were making rangolis. Her mom had already started theirs, as Saanvi could see her painting a bright floral pattern onto the wooden floor. Her mother gestured for Saanvi to come near her, and Saanvi decided to take on the annual rangoli contest with a positive intent.

“What do you think?” her mother said with pride.

“Umm,”

“Well? What do you think?”

“It’s okay, I guess, but I wouldn’t have used that shade—”

“Oh, for goodness sake, stop being such a perfectionist! You’re just like your father!” her mother responded playfully.

“That’s why we always won...”

Just then, her uncle walked in the room and started looking at the different rangolis. As he passed Saavi’s, he chuckled cockily.

“What?” Saanvi questioned defensively, eying his beady eyes.

“Let’s just put it this way, niece, at least my brother’s death was good for something!”

He had done it. Saanvi cried uncontrollably as she ran up the stairs and up to her room once more. Through her tears, Saanvi could hear her mother screaming at him like she had never

screamed before, saying things such as: “How could you be so insensitive?” followed by a series of slaps. However, it was all blurred out by Saanvi’s vile cries.

An hour passed, another one, then another one, and Saanvi’s cries had not gotten any quieter. She could see from her window that the sky was completely dark. Just then, Kaya opened the door in an attempt to comfort Saanvi.

“Saanvi,” she whispered, almost as if she was afraid that Saanvi would jump at her if she talked too loud.

“What do you want?”

“My dad can be a jerk sometimes. He is careless and does not realize what he says—he really is sorry.”

“You don’t know what it is like. Losing a father. It is like losing another part of you,”

“You’re right. But I can give you sympathy and tell you to enjoy the last few moments of the holiday that your father loved. Do you think he would have wanted you to celebrate the holiday crying over his loss?”

Saanvi looked up at Kaya, registering what she had just said.

“You know, for a seven year old, you are quite mature.”

“I know, now, let’s go light diyas!”

Kaya tugged Saanvi out of bed forcefully and practically pulled her down the stairs. Saanvi felt a slight grin spread across her face, and she felt grateful that Kaya was making her feel better.

Kaya tugged her out of the house and out to the large, dark garden. There, in the midst of the darkness, Saanvi could see, not one, but about two hundred diyas lit in front of her. There, in the darkness, she saw the silhouette of her mother’s relieved face, staring right at her. Instead of angrily talking to her, Saanvi let go of Kaya’s hand and went next to her mother, hugging her tightly. Saanvi’s mother hugged her back, while closing her eyes lovingly.

“Saanvi, there is something I would like to tell you,” her mother said, pulling Saanvi’s arm away slightly. “Do you know why there are so many diyas lit here tonight?”

“No,” Saanvi responded, a spark of curiosity in her voice.

“It is in memory of your father. Diyas symbolize care to those off the earth.”

Saanvi felt her heart warm with gratefulness, and she pulled her mom into a hug once more.

“So *everyone* lit diyas for father?”

“Yep. Our neighbors, our friends, our family, even Uncle Aaraav.”

“I’ll be right back,” Saanvi said suddenly, as she ran away from her mother, dodging the diyas that crossed her path.

There, sitting on top of a tree branch, Kaya sat smiling at the vast diyas in front of her.

“Help me up,” Saanvi said, stretching her arms out so Kaya could reach them. Kaya pulled Saanvi up after a vast amount of effort.

“I’m glad you came downstairs,” Kaya smiled.

“Me too. Now I know that my father still does live on,”

“Um...Saanvi...he is still dead...”

“I know, but he still lives on in my heart!”

With that, Kaya hugged Saanvi happily, as if she considered her as her sister. Saanvi hugged her back, joyousness pumping through her heart like blood.

Just then, Saanvi looked in the vast field of diyas, and, through the midst of the dark sky, he saw the silhouette of a man—whom she recognized. The same man that was in the portrait she had been weeping over for the past year. Saanvi saw her father's amber eyes staring at her kindly and she could have sworn that the corners of his mouth were pulled into a wide smile. Saanvi grinned back, knowing that her father would always be there with her in her life, dead or alive.

The Fear of St. Nicholas

By: Anika Sista

Fritz was excited. That was the only way to describe it. After three years of watching, his family bustled around the house baking cookies, preparing steak, and hanging the decorations he was *finally* going to be a part of. After all, St. Nicholas Day only happened once a year, so this was his moment to shine. A calendar sitting in his room only had a few important occasions marked and this was one of them. This was a big moment for him, as well as one of his only chances a year to see his distant family. This was his chance to prove to his brother Feliz and his parents that he was ready, and able to help when anyone needed anything. And so he did help, however he could, running around the house asking whether anyone needed help to the point where it started to get annoying.

“Fritz, can you *stop*?” Feliz said, annoyed. He was carrying a big pot of soup which he had intended to put on the table, until Fritz came running along as usual, and offered to help him.

“But I wanna help!” Fritz whined, his eagerness slowly fading away. Feliz rolled his eyes, a devilish grin appearing on his face.

“Fine, then you hold it,” he said, handing Fritz the pot, who took it with pleasure. However, this weight became too much for him and he struggled with the pot, trying to balance it before it toppled over. He got it to the table, only spilling a couple of drops before gasping and sitting down in a chair. His mom, who happened to be passing by, saw him.

“Come on, there’s still a lot to do!” she told him, “How about you set the table?” Fritz sighed before getting up, his muscles still aching. He grabbed the tablecloth, before slightly shifting his attention to his grandma standing in the kitchen, currently mixing butter and sugar in a bowl, humming distinctly under her breath. A few minutes passed as Fritz debated between the tasks. His eyes went back and forth, to the kitchen, to the table, the kitchen, the table. Abandoning the tablecloth, Fritz skipped over to his grandma, landing in front of her, eagerly watching for a few seconds before instantly asking if she needed assistance, to which she complied. Nearly jumping in the air with excitement, Fritz beamed and took the whisk as though it was a grand trophy before mixing his heart away. After several minutes, his hand started to hurt, but the work was worth it as the batter had reached the perfect consistency. Fritz looked to his grandma for permission before dipping his pointer finger in the batter and placing it in his mouth. A feeling of sweetness came over him, then a bombardment of flavors. He reached in for another lick but -

“Fritz, don’t do it again,” his grandma warned, “It’s not good for you.” Trying to hide the disappointment on his face, Fritz slowly walked away, running into his mom, who was holding his and Feliz’s shoes.

“Fritz,” she said, clearly displeased. “Didn’t I tell you to set the table?” Fritz automatically moved in the direction of the table, where the tablecloth lay on the floor.

“Um..well - I was *going to*..but - um..” he stammered. His mom sighed before placing the shoes on the floor and picking up the tablecloth.

“Please Fritz, just clean out your shoes, okay? St Nicholas is going to put candy in your shoes today, and they should be clean. Tell Feliz to do the same,” she said. It was only then that Fritz noticed how tired she looked and decided to do what she said. He weaved around the house, looking for Feliz, finally seeing him sitting on the couch, watching TV. Though Fritz was tempted to join him, he tore his eyes away from the screen and focused on Feliz, who was opening a bag of chips, Fritz’s favorite. Fritz looked at the bag, a longing look in his eyes, as he imagined biting into one of the salty, flavorful chips, and hearing the satisfying crunch as the flavors completely took over his body. He would reach for another, and another until the bag was empty. Fritz tried pushing all of these thoughts out of his mind.

“Feliz,” Fritz said, “Mom wants you to clean your shoes.” Feliz’s eyes stayed glued to the TV screen.

“Gimme a minute,” he mumbled, putting another chip in his mouth. This was too much for Fritz, who took the bag from Feliz and peeked into the bag, seeing a singular chip remaining, making Fritz’s hopes plummet to the ground. Feliz, who was quickly recovering from surprise, glared at Fritz and snatched the bag back, before eating the last chip and turning off the TV. He stomped to the hall and grabbed a bucket before going over to the sink and the sound of rushing water could be heard. When he returned, he placed the bucket on the ground and started washing the shoes. Fritz moved to clean his shoes too, but Feliz blocked him.

“Get your own,” he snapped, cleaning his shoes much too vigorously, and Fritz groaned before getting up to fill another bucket. He came back, the bucket dangerously shaking side to side, threatening to spill the water inside.

“So!” Fritz said, “Can you tell me things about St Nicholas Day?”

“Like what?” Feliz scowled.

“I dunno, just stuff.”

“What *stuff*?”

“I don’t know! Just like things about it!”

“You’re *so* annoying! You need to specify!”

It was conversations like these that made Fritz miss the times when he and Feliz got along. A fleeting memory passed Fritz’s mind when they went to the ice cream shop. He and Feliz ran around the shop, not giving a care in the world about the people watching them, or the ice cream dripping off the cone and onto their fingers. Now, looking at Feliz’s disgusted face, and annoyance at his little brother, he wondered where all that had gone. Feliz’s face, however, was slowly morphing into a devious grin, though he quickly concealed it.

“Hey, I know something about St Nicholas Day,” Feliz said innocently. Fritz, glad to hear this, sat, waiting.

“He’s called the Knecht Ruprecht. He’s a scary man wearing all black that comes with St Nicholas to all the houses and leaves sticks in all the bad kids’ boots. But, for the extra bad kids, he takes them from their beds and puts them in his bag, the perfect size for a kid, hmm probably your age.” Fritz, not expecting this, frowned, a scared look slowly coming on his face.

“He’s not going to take me away, right Feliz?” Fritz asked, horrible images appearing in his mind.

“It depends,” Feliz shrugged, “Have you been a good kid this year?” Fritz stopped to think, and recalled the time when he ate the cookie that Ada, the girl across the street had given Feliz, who instantly turned red at the sight of Fritz’s icing-covered face. *But*, his mind argued, *how could I’ve known that it was Feliz’s? It might’ve been a 4 month-early birthday gift!* But even with that reassuring thought, another image swept into his mind, him throwing a tantrum at the arcade because his favorite game glitched, and everyone covering their ears at the wailing that filled the room. *It was understandable, that was everyone’s favorite game and it just stopped working!* But as each scenario rose into Fritz’s mind, he tried clearing them, but part of him was scared. Was he a bad kid? Feliz had already left, having finished washing his shoes, but Fritz’s still lay dirty, and as he tried scrubbing at some of the spots, just like his thoughts, only some things would disappear.

An hour passed, and Fritz brought his still slightly dirty shoes out onto the porch, the cold winter air welcoming to him, as he admired the colorful decorations adorning the houses on the snow-covered streets. A faint scent of spices was in the air, nutmeg and cinnamon, a sign of the cookies that were being baked in the majority of the houses. The sound of children's laughter was bright and cheerful, and the imprints of their feet as they played in the snow were noticeable, giving the atmosphere a sense of serenity. For a moment, Fritz forgot all about the Knecht Ruprecht, and he was happy, but a draft of wind came over him, and he shivered, the entire scene seemed to instantly darken. He went back inside to see all of his family starting to sit at the table, talking and laughing. Fritz’s mom beckoned for him to join her, a weary smile on her face as she patted the seat next to her. Fritz’s stomach rumbled and he sat down, breathing in the aroma of freshly baked cookies, and looking at the big pot of soup, which he had placed on the table himself. Pouring himself a generous amount into his bowl, Fritz took a sip and was surprised at the heat of the soup. Eyes watering, he waited a bit, before taking another sip and properly enjoying it. The fish flavor was prominent and the different spices and flavors burst in his mouth, and he took multiple more sips before scanning the rest of the table. Seeing the bread basket, he took a piece and bit into it, the softness of the bread being almost overwhelming and the butter being perfect. Fritz ate and ate some more, so much food he started to feel sleepy. The cookies properly woke him up, however, and he stared at them, a longing look in his eyes, knowing they would taste equally good or better than the batter version, and they did not disappoint. After 2 or three cookies and a soft, sweet, perfectly flipped, and golden brown pfannkuchen, Fritz was falling asleep while walking up the stairs and only managed to brush his teeth, before he plopped onto his bed and instantly closed his eyes.

Fritz woke up sometime later, and groggily looked around before rolling over and looking at the clock which read 2:27. All the events from the night before suddenly came rushing into his mind and he remembered all that delicious food, before recollecting his conversation with Feliz. An evil, smiling man dressed in all black came into his mind and he suddenly sat up,

the fear returning, and he looked around, expecting to see the Knecht Ruprecht jump out at him. Part of him wanted to hide under the covers, to try and prevent the Knecht Ruprecht from taking him, but the other part wanted to, maybe go downstairs and look around, see if he was there- no he must not, what if once he was taken, no one would ever know where he went. At least if he stayed here, he could scream and his parents might come, maybe stop the Knecht Ruprecht from taking him..yes that was a good idea. A smile on his face, Fritz rolled over and tried to sleep, but found he couldn't. Again and again, that idea came into his head..go downstairs..just go..what could happen? Fritz couldn't take it anymore and slowly exited his room. The hallway was dark, and Fritz could barely see, as he slowly crept down the stairs, using the railing as a guide to lead him. Once downstairs, Fritz noted how much creepier it looked at night, and looked back to the stairs, contemplating whether he should go back up. He stood there for a few seconds, heart pounding, and chose to keep going. The living room was dark and Fritz thought that the Knecht Ruprecht must be hiding behind a chair, or the couch, but when he looked in those places, nothing was there. Unable to take the suspense, Fritz opened the front door and looked out towards the street, which was dimly lit by the streetlights. He didn't see St Nichols or the Knecht Ruprecht, but upon looking down at his and Feliz's shoes, he saw they were filled to the top, not with sticks, but with a variety of candy, so much that the shoes were overfilling. This sight relieved Fritz, and he nearly skipped back inside before going upstairs to his room, a smile on his face.

Winterlude without Grandma

By: Meghna Srivashini

Lily woke up to the sound of her older sister in the bathroom. This wasn't normal. Lily has never been woken up by the sound of her sister showering. Lily got out of bed to see what was going on, but the second she saw what her mother was wearing, it hit her.

"Winterlude," Lily whispered, her voice full of sorrow and regret. She looked down at her mother from the top of the stairs and watched as her father walked over to comfort her mother, who now seemed to be staring at a photo. But not just a normal photo, the last photo she took of grandma. Lily felt her eyes begin to water but she pushed the feeling away and went back into her room. She knew exactly where they were going, the exact place she's been avoiding for the past year.

"They're going to grandma's grave," Lily muttered to herself, "If I don't go out, they'll think I'm still sleeping. Right?" Lily said to herself. Just then, Lily heard footsteps coming towards her room. Lily pulled the covers over her head and closed her eyes.

"Lily, wake up -" Lily could hear her older sister's voice stop, "Oh, you're still sleeping." Lily could hear her slowly slip out of the room and silently close the door, but even though she left, Lily didn't have the energy to get up anymore. It was too painful. Lily stayed in bed until she heard the door close and the sound of footsteps were gone. Lily suddenly felt tears coming,

"Why did she have to die? Why?" Lily sobbed. Her grandmother had died just after Winterlude ended last year, and Lily hasn't visited the grave since the funeral. Lily started to wipe the tears from her face as she got out of bed and got dressed to go to the carnival. She might as well try to get the topic of her grandmother off of her mind.

"I'll be back before mom gets home," Lily assures herself. As Lily walked down the stairs she could already see the bright lights and wreaths hung up for Winterlude. The second Lily walked out the door a wave of the cool air rushed into her face. A smile lit up into her face as she walked out to the brightly lit street. The colorfully blinding parade floats dazzled next to the shimmering white snow, which was now indented with the sole of peoples shoes, ruining the perfect texture of the snow. The masquerade on the ice had already begun and kids, adults and even grandmas were skating with their loved ones on the frigid ice. Lily watched them in envy, knowing that she would never be able to feel the absolute joy when she skated on the ice with her beloved grandma, never be able to walk through these Winterlude streets that always filled her grandma's heart with happiness. The ice sculptures had already been hung up, on the balconies of peoples houses, which made Lily remember the time where she and her grandma had made the most flawless ice sculptures but the second they tried to hang them up, they were too heavy and they crashed to the ground. Her and her grandma were hysterical about it and couldn't stop laughing. People had stared at them, but they didn't care, everything was perfect back then. But nothing would be the same, ever. Her grandmother was not coming back. Lily's smile disappeared as she continued to walk through the parades. She kept her head down because she didn't want to make eye contact with anyone. The whole town knew about Lily's

grandmother's death, and they all missed her and Lily was grateful for it, but all the people did was show sympathy to them. Lily could already hear them whispering,

"Oh poor girl, having to go through that at such a young age,"

"Nothing has ever been the same since her grandmother left," Lily heard a woman whispering. The other woman responded,

"I think she's being a little dramatic. It's been an entire year since her death and she's still sulking over it." Lily felt intense anger rising in her,

"How about you try losing your best friend!" Lily muttered in anger. She was sick of these kinds of people. Do they not have anything else to gossip about?

"*Lily. Lily. I know you can hear me,*" a voice whispered in Lily's head, "*Go to the canoe race,*" Lily clutched her head in fear,

"What! Who are you?" Lily said, anxiously. But the voice was gone. For some reason, Lily felt an urge to follow the voices. As though they were leading her somewhere.

"I guess there's no harm in going to the canoe race," Lily said to herself. Lily was always amazing at the canoe races. She and her would beat everyone there. But it was never Lily's favorite because her grandmother couldn't participate with her. As Lily walked, she kept her head down. She could still hear the whispers,

"Isn't that girl whose grandmother died last year?"

"Oh my gosh, I can't believe she's still coming to Winterlude even after her grandmother is not here," Lily pulled her hood down lower to cover her ears from the whispers. She controlled the severe amount of anger she felt for the people

"*Why can't they just mind their own business?*" Lily questioned. As she entered the canoe racing area, she saw as the teams got their gear on. Canoe racing was like a real sport and it was taken very seriously during Winterlude. It's a tough sport requiring a lot of intelligence and athletic ability. The second Lily walked into the viewing area for the race, she didn't even have to look up to know that eyes were on her. She could feel their burning stares. Lily felt sweat drip down her back as she elbowed her way to the front of the race.

BEEP! The horn sounded and the canoe racers took off. Lily felt a smile form on her face as she watched them struggle to get through the ice, mixed with slush and water. She and her grandmother had always laughed until their stomachs hurt watching the teams try to get over the mounds of ice piling on top of each other. They knew it was wrong but it made them happy. For the first time in months, Lily felt pure joy watching the teams.

"Hello," Lily whipped around and found a girl around her age talking to her.

"*Talk to her,*" Lily's eyes widened. The voice was back.

"Is everything alright," the girl asked, "I apologize if I frightened you."

"No, everything's fine." Lily responded, "Who are you exactly?"

"You don't know me? I'm Fiona." the girl responded, "I live across the street from you? I go to your school?"

"Oh Fiona! I remember you," Fiona had just moved in last year from America. Lily had never thought of becoming friends with her because she moved in just shortly after her grandmother passed away.

"I saw you walking this way and I thought you would like some company!" Fiona said. Lily didn't really feel like talking to Fiona right now but she didn't want to seem rude,

"Oh okay," Lily looked back at the canoe race, "Do you want to stay here or -" Fiona cut Lily off,

"Do you want to go to the masquerade on the ice? I heard it's really cool this year!" Lily suddenly felt broken. She had been avoiding the area ever since she walked out the door. Looking at it wouldn't make anything better.

"It's probably going to be crowded," Lily made up an excuse, "Do you want to go check out the parade floats?" Lily asked.

"Of course! And I can get to know you better on the way there!" Fiona said as we walked away.

"Perfect!" Lily muttered sarcastically to herself.

"What was that?" Fiona asked.

"Nothing," Lily said quickly.

"So, what is your favorite childhood memory?" Fiona asked.

"My favorite childhood memory would be when my grandmother took me skating at the lake. There were plenty of signs telling us we weren't supposed to, but everyone in the town knew that the ice got thick enough to skate on. Even the authorities knew it. Families from everywhere came to take their kids to skate. My mother hadn't approved of my grandma taking me skating there, but my grandma's not like others, she's a rule breaker," Lily responded.

"Oh yeah I know that lake. I didn't know we weren't allowed to skate on it."

"Yeah, the signs are all covered up in snow so you can't really see them," Lily explained.

"Interesting, so you must miss her a lot?" Fiona said in sympathy. Lily could hear that Fiona was being sympathetic and she hated it, but she pushed the anger away,

"Yes, a lot actually. I remember once she used to ask me if I had one superpower what would I choose. I had said that I wanted to be able to teleport,"

"I suppose you have changed that choice," Fiona inquired. "And have you ever had any fears in your life? Cause I know I have!" Fiona chuckled, trying to lighten up the mood. Lily nodded,

"When I was about 5 years old, I used to sneak downstairs every weekend with my grandma and go to the park without my mother's consent. I used to be so afraid that she would catch us, but grandma always told me that she wouldn't. And then 3 years later she fell sick. And suddenly, my biggest fear was losing her." Lily's eyes started to water but she wiped them away,

"Next question?" Fiona asked. Lily smiled and nodded.

"Right," Fiona obviously felt bad but proceeded to ask the next question, "What is your ideal day?"

"I'm not sure. Everyday feels exactly the same. Like nothing will ever change." Lily's eyes were sorrowful and her voice was full of regret.

"Oh, I understand," Fiona said, "Oh look we're here!" They looked at the parade floats in awe. Whoever made these obviously put a lot of effort into it.

"I actually have to go now. It was nice meeting you though," Fiona obviously wanted to get away from Lily.

"Oh no! I didn't mean to kill the mood," Lily forced a laugh.

"No it's not you. I just have to get home before my mother gets worried." Fiona lied and ran off

"Oh great!" Lily muttered, "Now she doesn't want to talk to me." Lily checked the time and saw she had plenty of time before her parents got home.

"I know you've been avoiding it! Visit the grave. You might learn something," Lily screamed as the voices came back into her head. She suddenly realized how loud she was and she looked around and saw all eyes on her. The whispers began immediately,

"She must be crazy!" A woman muttered to the other.

"I'm not crazy!" Lily screeched back and she ran off into the woods. She had no clue where she was going, she just wanted to get away from everything; the people; the stares; the whispers. Suddenly Lily didn't see where she was going and she tripped over a fallen branch. Lily fell to the ground, hard. She clutched her knee which was now bruised and bleeding. Lily fell to the ground and sobbed.

"Why does it have to be like this?" she wept. Lily looked up and she recognized this place. It was a cemetery. Lily fought the pain away as she limped into the cemetery. There were families next to graves, decorating them with fresh flowers and other things. Lily limped around and suddenly she saw a name that made her heart skip a beat.

"Anne Rodriguez," Lily said out loud. She limped over to the grave and fell to her knees. This was the first time she had visited the grave since the funeral. The funeral where they buried her. The funeral where Lily had cried her eyes out till they were red and puffy. Lily felt two hands land on her shoulders, but she knew who they belonged to.

"Honey, when did you get here," Lily heard her mom's soft voice. Lily didn't have the energy to respond but instead started crying.

"Why did she have to leave?" Lily bawled.

"Her time just ran out," Lily's mom said. Lily wiped the tears from her eyes and looked at the grave.

"Did you get any flowers?" Lily asked. Lily's mom handed her a bouquet of pink flowers, "Her favorite color," Lily's mom nodded. Lily got up and placed the flowers in front of the grave.

"Goodbye Grandma," Lily said, and walked away.